

HOMO FANTASMA

HUGO CUENOT



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I'm late again, putting on my jeans in a hurry, wreaking havoc as I stumble around on one foot, the lamp on my nightstand falling to the floor, its fall cushioned by the pile of dirty clothes and plastic wrappers sitting by my bed. I let my hand pick up a shirt in the pile without even looking and put it on in a hurry while I look for my papers hiding in the pocket of a coat, or a vest, or pants. I take a quick look at myself in the mirror, I look terrible, I wish I hadn't looked. I put on my shoes without bothering to tie my laces, grab my bag and leave. It's still night outside, the wind is cold on my arms and I can feel tiny droplets of water hitting my neck. I run in the dark, the city lights are out, the sky is pitch black, it feels like running in a dark tunnel.

I sprint by the city clock, its large hands that seemed to follow me, here to mock me and remind me that I'm impossibly late. Still on I go under the canopy of trees protecting me from

the rain, getting stronger. The streets are empty, no vehicles, no one loitering, not even a stray cat. The streets, sanitized of all life, even the trees are silent in the wind, their leaves like made of plastic don't seem to brush against each other, they don't seem to fall down either, the pavement under my feet is immaculate. The thoughts flash through my head, my mind focused in the distance. My feet hit the ground, resonating in the empty street, the untied shoelaces hitting the ground lightly, creating a perfectly balanced melody, waiting for nothing but my fall when I inevitably walk on it, putting an end to it.

For now, I keep running, carried by the urge to get there, lifted by the trust I have in my own feet, knowing they won't fail me. I run by a vending machine, its blue light lighting my path, and for a second, I think about stopping and getting a cold drink to quench my rising thirst. It has been a minute since I last ran, my legs remembered but my heart seems surprised by the effort. My throat is dry; my lungs start to hurt with my breath getting shorter with every step I take. I check my watch and do the math between the distance I need to go and the speed I'm going at. I'm still late and keep running under the black sky. In this part of town, store

fronts light my way, a light carpet leading directly to my stop. I run the avenue, passing by neon lights desperately trying to catch my attention, desperately trying to sell me their precious objects lit up in the belly of the display cases.

Today, or rather tonight I have no time, no attention to give them. I see my stop, at the end of the street. I see the shuttle I'm supposed to take. It's waiting, empty, I see inside of it, the white seats empty. I slow down a bit, giving my heart a break, a wave of relief gaining me. But the rest is short, for the moment I started slowing down, the shuttle simply turned on and left, still empty. I check my watch again; late. I try to run after it, but with the rain getting stronger, and my legs failing me, I simply give up.

I go back to the stop and decide that despite having a ticket for the one that just drove a few meters away from me, I will take the next one, I will just have to wait here, in the empty street, under the rain coming from the dark sky that seemed to swallow the whole city. I stand by the lamppost throwing a soft orange light barely a meter around it. Water is now cascading down my forehead, so I just stare at my feet while the drops hit me behind my head. I stay like this, without moving, for a moment. My clothes are drenched; water simply rolls off of my t-shirt

now and falls on my legs. I tie up my shoes that I have been staring down at, saving me from a future fall. I'm fully dissociating when the new shuttle stops right in front of me.

The rain has doubled and I hurry inside through the opposite door. It is spacious inside, I can stand up almost straight, my head touching the soft ceiling. A puddle of water starts to pool at my feet; I regret not packing an extra shirt in my bag. There are two cushioned benches facing each other, and I simply fall on one of them, letting the warmth of the inside dry my bones. My bag, also drenched, sits by my side. I look around, looking for a vent exhausting hot air and try to sit as close to it as possible. I shiver, looking at my hands, the calming noise of the rain on the roof rocking me to a soft slumber. The shuttle remains silent and unmoving. The door to my right opens, a man in a black rain-coat enters.

He's drenched, water rolling off his coat. He has a cap screwed on his head, and large work boots leaving dark streaks behind the white floor of the shuttle. He lets his body down in a grunt on the other side. He removes his cap, letting his hair darkened by the water fall on his forehead. He has nice, symmetrical features, eyes

deep in his skull, giving him a dark and intense look. He looks surprised to see somebody else in there with him but doesn't say a word, he simply nods. He has a large bag with him that he sets on the floor by his feet. A few seconds later, the shuttle starts and the dark landscape outside starts to move. It is now two men in this white moving cage of metal, emitting this low light around itself. Trying to look outside is pointless, the streets, pitch black, don't offer any sort of entertainment. After a floating moment of silence, only interrupted by the rustling of the coat when he moves, he introduces himself.

After an exchange of polite introductions and names, everyone returns to their occupation, staring at the window. He keeps moving in his seat, making this uncomfortable noise over and over with his coat, until eventually he decides to remove it. He reveals a white t-shirt sticking to his skin from his chest up, from the rain that had run down. When he removes his coat, a faint smell of sweat starts to rise in the small compartment, replacing the smell of the rain and mud. He's one of those restless guys, biting his nails, shaking his leg like an impatient person would do while waiting. But there was nothing to wait for here really, except for the trip.

Nothing to be anxious about in the small white shuttle.

Still on, the fast thumping and regular nail-tearing took over the rocking music of the rain. He has a powerful chest, and large arms, visible under the tight, wet, white t-shirt. The chest and arms of someone who works out for the aesthetic of it, these are not muscles that have lifted heavy weights for work or necessity. His hands, small and delicate, have never seen hardship, apart from his tearing teeth cutting and stripping away nail and skin. His legs however seem powerful in his pants; his large thighs pressing against the fabric of his black pants. His imposing figure is stressed by the scale of the room, his head almost touching the ceiling. Silence reigns for a long while, until he reaches for his bag and starts to go through it. He is going through his large black bag, looking for something. His arm disappears and starts to move around, feeling for something. A mass of fabric is starting to overflow from the top of the bag, probably clothes. But that's not what he's looking for. He closes his eyes, focusing on what his hand feels at the bottom of the bag. He starts to take out some of the clothes on top of the bag then starts to look deeper, his head almost inside. He takes out a compact mirror. A small, round, black

compact mirror. He opens it and starts to look at himself meticulously.

I look at him, looking at himself. He doesn't even notice me staring, or he simply doesn't care. He starts at the root of his hair above his forehead, slowly touching his skin, making sure that it's still tight and wrinkle-free. He goes by, centimeter by centimeter, checking his skin. For a second I wonder if maybe he could just be checking for a disease or something. But the way he proceeds, staring up from really close, then looking back to see his whole face reinforces this idea that this is all just a vanity concern. After the forehead comes the nose, then the cheeks.

Every centimeter of his face is being carefully scrutinized under his eye. It has an off-putting effect to see this large man with his dark eyes just look at himself with such intensity in such a small mirror, it's almost comical. When I think about it, I have never looked at myself like this, I have never indulged in my own reflection this much, but maybe I am missing something, maybe there is some truth in the depth of my skin, in the pores, in the cells, and maybe I would have to take a good look at it.

I scratch my forehead mechanically, feeling the greasy, almost mushy skin under my finger. I felt the small bumps on my textured skin, like thick, wet paper. Now he's checking a small pimple on his chin, small and red. He makes it roll between his fingers, pressing it hard, trying to pop it. But it doesn't seem ready yet. He even checks the inside of his nose. I look away and start to look at him through the reflection in the window, pretending to look outside. He puts down the mirror, and digs back in his bag, in one of the lateral pockets. He takes out a small pair of tweezers, and with one hand, holds the mirror to his face, and the other starts plucking some loose hair on his face. Not only around the eyebrows, but he also goes around the beard area, then the ears, and finishes with the nose. Every hair he takes out ends up on the floor, simply dropping it down at his feet. I am fascinated by this whole ritual, the comfort needed to do this with such ease and owning it and turning this into a spectacle for me to enjoy. After he has decided that his face is clear from any and all problems, he closes the compact mirror and puts the tweezers back in the bag. He looks at me and smiles, then stares outside to the blackness.

Outside, the rain has stopped. Inside, every-

thing has dried, still bathed in this white-ish light, almost like an egg lit up from the inside traveling a million kilometers an hour in the void. Inside the two embryos still facing each other, in a muted silence, vibrating in the shuttle. A certain camaraderie has settled, without more than ten words having been uttered. Now a new game has started; a sort of stare-off, a game of looks. Between chasing and attracting, the eyes dart left and right, peeking in the windows' reflection. Maybe he found something in the reflection of his compact mirror, maybe he has gained some confidence back, and now he wants to confront it to reality. The reality is sitting in front of him, so that's where he is trying it. His dark eyes and dark brows, heavy with a strong, almost palpable energy, throwing quick glances. The reciprocated looks keep missing each other by milliseconds, both just passing the other, in a dance of the lashes. At some point, the four eyes locked and something was exchanged in the process, but it's hard to know what for now. The stare-off ends without a loser, and a new calm settles. He's getting restless again, shaking his leg, looking out the window, scratching his arm.

He turns to me. I look at him straight in the eyes, again, but this time it is voluntary. He looks at me for a second, and I can tell that he wants to say something. He is still scratching his arm, his sentence still on his tongue. He's asking a question with his eyes, until he finally pronounces the words. He asks me if I am fine with him doing a little workout routine to pass the time. I shrug and nod.

The shuttle is spacious enough for a small workout, still I'm afraid that this will get a little bit awkward. He stands up, his head bent, touching the ceiling. He is towering over me, almost menacing. He starts by stretching his arms, then his legs. He is so close to me, I can smell him, feel his body warmth. Then he starts to punch the air in front of him, challenging his reflection in the window. I can't help but stare, his ample and noisy movements catching my eye. I'm looking at this show like a parade, a mating dance. Him, trying to prove something to himself, or to me. All of a sudden, he drops to the floor. I jump in surprise, ready to give him assistance, but he starts to do some push-ups. Up down up down up down. He is quick, and I'm flabbergasted by the situation. His feet touch one door, his head grazing the other opposite

one. His elbows tucked by his sides still brush against the seats every time he goes down. He breathes heavily. I lose count after twenty-five. Once again, this seems like an exercise in proving something, but I'm still unsure what, I cannot put my finger on what he's trying to achieve. He must have reached fifty when he stood up in a flash, still breathing heavily. He takes his pulse, throws a quick glance in my direction, catching me watching him incredulously.

For the next few minutes, he does a bunch of leg-related exercises, making his white t-shirt that had dried, wet again, drenched in sweat. The aroma here is getting slightly funkier. Down on the floor he goes again, grunting up and down, doing push-ups in front of me. I'm speechless in front of this behavior, I still don't know how to react to this, whether I should encourage him or try to ignore him. Caught between the choices, I just stare at him, not impervious to the charm of a man performing for my own pleasure. And that idea of the pleasure really takes off when standing back up panting and sweating profusely, he removes his t-shirt revealing a glistening torso.

He does ask, rhetorically, if I mind, there is little point for me to refuse, or manifest any discomfort. I really don't mind the show, and his

face really says that he is doing this for the pleasure of showing off. His skin-tight t-shirt wasn't lying about his physique, his pumped chest and his big arms. I try not to laugh when he very caricaturally starts to flex looking at himself, then crossing my gaze in the mirror and reading the pure satisfaction in his eyes. I'm having a hard time thinking that this is real, and it is happening to me. Yet here he is, back on the ground, counting out loud his push-ups. He is turning this place into a gym. The mirrors, the grunting, the smell, the man taking up all the space, I'm sent right back in a stuffy room.

He then proceeds to do some rather complicated calisthenic movements, bending in impossible positions, and stretching in positions defying gravity. At some point, he removes his shoes, wishing that he had removed them before his workout, before he started sweating profusely, before his white socks turned grey. I'm scooching over to the door, pressed against the wall, trying to make myself as tiny as possible while the man is doing his exercises. I'm detailing his back that he has turned to me while he is doing the last stretching, announcing the end of the workout.

He is dripping, but I'm starting to sweat as well,

the air heated by the effort, and my body, flushed, probably by the pheromones that I keep breathing inside this pod. He stands up again, breathing hard, his heart beating in his neck, looks at me and tells me that he's done with his workout. He sits back down in front of me, fanning himself with his hands, his upper body red hot from the heat. The windows cannot be opened, it feels humid and stuffy. I shake my shirt to try and ventilate myself, only stirring up warm air around me. I pass my hand over the vent to check the air conditioning, but my fingers only get hot air. I look around for a control button to turn it off, or find the cool air button, to no avail.

The space is slowly turning into a sauna, the windows covered in a thin layer of water, the walls too probably. A malfunction, a glitch or a hidden jokester made the vents start to blow even hotter air for a while, stuffing the air-tight pod with heat. The sweat and every ounce of water contained in the air is getting vaporized, creating a slow, rising cloud of vapor in the air that turns into droplets when it reaches the smooth ceiling or the cold windows in contact with the exterior. The cloud starts to cling on to the clothes, penetrating, rendering everything slight-

ly wet, a bit heavier, making the bodies hotter. The doors won't open, and putting the bags in front of the vents isn't really helping. Every surface is getting hotter, soon, layers of clothes have to be removed, revealing more skin, trying to let the pores breathe from the smothering clothes. Shoes are put as far away as possible, their metallic parts starting to singe at the feet. The brows, a constant barrier from the sweat pouring down the forehead, and the pits a river digging a trough down the sides. It becomes this surreal scene where two men travel through a lightless night down to their underwear, sitting in this accidental heat box – a sauna of some sorts.

I wouldn't have imagined, when I left earlier, running under the rain, that I would end up, in the same day, in my underwear sweating profusely in a moving shuttle, a stranger across from me, in the same situation. I must have stumbled somewhere in hell, for this heat has to be sent by an evil being. I tried to keep my composure and my clothes on for as long as I could, but he was so quick to finish removing his clothes, happy to keep showing off his physique.

I didn't want to get my clothes off but the heat made my clothes so heavy on my back, the

humidity skyrocketing inside made it slowly unbearable. My shoes felt ten times heavier, I wasn't mad about taking them off, even if the whiff I got from them made me feel a little bit self-conscious. I had to let go of the socks as well, revealing unflattering toes, already feeling more naked than if I were properly naked. Something in me makes me feel like showing my naked feet would reveal more than I feel comfortable, like you could read into me more easily, something that you're not supposed to. Removing them did feel good.

But that didn't prevent my back and my chest from drenching my shirt, my armpits a warm pool. At that point he was sitting down, wearing nothing but his black underwear. I didn't want to stare, but I noticed the hole right under the elastic waistline on his hip, showing a patch of lighter skin. Shifting my focus on him allowed me to avoid thinking of the blazing heat coming off in a constant stream. His hair has reached the same state they were in when he first came through, wet and dark. No amount of muscle, soft glistening skin, hairy carpeted legs could really overshadow the situation, that's when I caved in and removed my shirt. It feels good, and for a moment I feel relieved.

But every time I breathe, the air burns my nostrils a little bit. I catch him staring at my shapeless body, my bare skin. I use the dirty shirt to wipe off the sweat from my face and my pits, then throw it on the floor. When I look back at him, he pretends to look outside the window, wiping the condensation off of the window, staring at the blackness. I feel so vulnerable, but I keep undressing, the heat becoming dangerous now. I let my pants fall down my ankle and wished I was wearing a more decent underwear.

The two of us, now almost entirely stripped down, look at each other, then we simply start laughing, the laughs swallowed by the cloud floating between us. We decide that if this is not getting better fast, we will have to act, to do something. For now, we try to enjoy the hellhole we found ourselves in, exchanging pleasantries. He is beaming with pride every time he catches me staring at one of his congested members, still pumped after his earlier workout, his blood vessels dilated by the heat. I swear that the vents must have been spitting steam because as time passes, we can see less and less of each other sitting across each other. I can see the wisps of steam rise in front of me, curling around my lashes. The air is thick, the sounds muffled. I hear

him, he starts to bang on the window. Nothing happens, the humming of the shuttle doesn't falter, the window remains shut. Through the fog I see him scrape the sweat from his chest and throw it on the floor. Something inside of me almost lunges after it, my reptilian brain desperate for water, and my horny brain desperate for anything remotely sensual.

My mouth is dry; my head is starting to spin a little bit. I'm reaching my limit, only now am I starting to get scared of the situation. My heart starts beating faster in my chest, but I try to suppress the wave of panic that is trying to take a hold of me. We look at each other for a second, our eyes wide open, reading in his eyes the same repressed panic that he can probably read in mine. I lie down on the bench on my side, to calm my nerves. The surface a few degrees colder than my skin offers a brief relief. I close my eyes for a second, but when I open them again, we are in pitch darkness.

The dark has swallowed the shuttle. The night has made its way inside, in a second. The soft white light has died down leaving a heavy silence in the pod. The vent has stopped spewing hot air, the heat escaping slowly through the glass windows. Outside, the night remains eternal,

dark and cold. Inside, two breaths are synchronizing in a now pleasant warmth that stopped sticking to the skin, but rather enveloped softly the naked bodies, now invisible to the other. The silence becomes heavier, the low rumbling of the shuttle almost a distant whisper now. Not one movement, not one word dares to break the spell. The sound of the droplets of water falling from every surface fill up the air, alas it is raining inside. The air slowly becomes breathable again; the blood cools and the hearts slow.

Droplets fall from the ceiling on my head and my shoulders, like a tree sweating in the summer, almost painful in its surprise. I don't really understand what is happening. One second, we're almost dying, and the other we're in total darkness. Something must've happened, but the shuttle is still moving. I hit my hand against the door trying to reach for the window and I hear him flinch in front of me, surprised by the sudden noise. I wipe off the window again, but I still can't see anything outside. I press my forehead against the cold glass and I stay there until the window warms up under my skin. I'm disoriented. I'm calmer, my breath regular, my heart has calmed down. I hear him shuffle, in front of me, maybe searching his bag, or simply moving

around. I like being invisible for the moment, almost as if I were absent.

Almost as if I were alone, or he wasn't here. It smells like flesh, like bodies. My hair, skin are drying slowly, disappearing into the night. I put my back against the inside of the shuttle and spread my legs in front of me, pushing some of my clothes in the process, dropping with a mat sound. We stay like this for a while, the silence rocking me, I think I fell asleep with my eyes open. I come back to reality with noises next to me, a rubbing sound, almost like a caress on the pages of a book. I turn my head to hear better, then ask if everything is alright. Apparently yes, he is simply touching himself, running his hands on his arms, his legs. Running it against his chest and his nipples. He tells me to do as much, that it feels really good, it anchors to reality when everything around seems to go awry. When you can't even see yourself, you know you're still here by feeling yourself. He guides me, and together we touch our own body ritually, from the feet up, feeling the rugous skin, the thin skin, the hairy skin, the oily skin, the hot skin, the rough skin, the million textures that my soft fingers find below them. His voice is guiding me, a trail in the dark, falling into me. As he goes, it becomes a whisper, a murmur co-

ming from deep within his throat, guiding me along my body. This voice, coming from deep within the dark becomes my hand, becomes my own voice, it becomes a light to follow. The worship of my own body in the dark room feels incredible. To simply indulge in myself and to let go. His voice surrounds me, resonating everywhere, vibrating in my chest. Then it stops, and as his voice dies down, my hands fall beside me.

Our breath takes up all the space, swallowed by the dark. It's like he's right by my ear; I can almost feel his hot breath brushing against me. I can almost feel his warm skin right by my shoulder and his hand hovering above my chest radiating heat. I can almost smell him right by me, that salty spice smell that I have grown accustomed to now, but for some reason, smells stronger in the dark. I'm staring at the dark, but my eyes could very much be piercing right through his chiseled face a few centimeters above me. I put my hands up to dissipate the ghost I had made up in my mind and sit back down. He's shuffling in front of me. I ask him what to do now. We stay like this, looking at each other across the emptiness. When I turn my head, pearls of light speckle the night sky. I get closer, drawn by the light like a moth to a flame. The stars have

shown up, shining their distant light, reflecting lightly on the droplets still clinging to the glass. I sense his face next to mine, staring outside. Their lights were still not strong enough to light either of us yet I could see him bright next to me. A grinding noise wakes us up from our reverie, coming from the shuttle's body outside. The grinding slowly turns into a squeaking noise, coming from everywhere, giving us the impression to get closer.

Outside the star still passing by us, unbothered. The squeaking turns into a trembling, shaking below our feet. My hands look for something to hold in the darkness, holding onto the door and the bench. I wonder how we could still be going. Something pushes me to the ground in a screeching noise. I fall to my knees, my head hitting what feels like his legs. I try to sit back up, but the bench has been swallowed by something pushing from the outside, crushing us slowly inside. I feel his hands reach for me to help me up when another screech throws him against me. I hear the windows break under the invisible force. Above us, the ceiling is slowly caving in in a low quaking noise. Our bodies are mingling and I have no idea when mine starts and his ends. A gust of wind blows on my back

a cold air that almost hurts. The panels keep getting closer, my head is projected somewhere on some lukewarm, soft flesh. He falls entirely on top of me, now I can make up his body and mine.

We both end up in a fetal position, our bodies interlocking. If I lift my eyes, I can see the stars. The noises stop. We're still stuck, in this pod, this egg shaped coffin. We're both breathing, our naked bodies pressed against each other, the yolk and the white. The shuttle is still going, the stars flying by faster and faster, as I press a little bit tighter against his back.